# Pulp Fiction

## A Companion Guide

Media type: Movie (1994, directed by Quentin Tarantino)

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Spoiler tier: Full spoilers. This guide discusses the entire plot, including the ending.

## Quick Take

Pulp Fiction is the 1994 crime film that rewired how movies get to tell stories. Three interlocking Los Angeles crime tales, two hitmen, one boxer who refuses to throw a fight, a gangster's wife, an overdose, a glowing briefcase, and a timeline shuffled so thoroughly that a main character dies in the middle and walks out of the movie alive at the end. It won the Palme d'Or at Cannes, earned seven Oscar nominations, turned an $8 million budget into $214 million worldwide, and put the word Tarantino-esque into the dictionary of film criticism. Critics remain close to unanimous: 92 percent on Rotten Tomatoes and a 95 on Metacritic. If you have any interest in movies as a craft, it is essential viewing. It is also profane, violent, and proudly lurid, which is exactly what the title promises: the film opens with the dictionary definition of pulp, and everything after is Tarantino making his own lurid crime magazine on screen.

## The Source

Pulp Fiction is an original screenplay, but it has a genuinely tangled origin story. It began in the late 1980s when Quentin Tarantino and Roger Avary were clerks at Video Archives, a video store in Manhattan Beach, California. The initial idea was an anthology of three short crime films, modeled on Mario Bava's 1963 horror anthology Black Sabbath and provisionally titled Black Mask, after the pulp magazine that launched hardboiled crime fiction and published Dashiell Hammett and Raymond Chandler. That three-story skeleton survived intact into the finished film: Vincent Vega and Marsellus Wallace's Wife, The Gold Watch, and The Bonnie Situation.

Tarantino wrote most of the script in Amsterdam, starting in March 1992 and finishing in January 1993. Avary joined him there and brought along a feature screenplay he had written in 1990 called Pandemonium Reigns. Its core, a boxer named Butch Coolidge who double-crosses a gangster and goes back for a precious gold watch, became the entire middle section of the film. Two more Avary-written scenes, originally drafted for True Romance, were folded into The Bonnie Situation: the miracle of the hidden gunman's missed shots and the accidental shooting of Marvin in the back seat. Amsterdam itself leaks into the movie. Vincent's opening riff about hash bars and the Royale with Cheese comes straight from Tarantino's time there.

Then comes the fault line in the legend. Avary was originally slated for a co-writing credit, but before release Tarantino persuaded him to accept a story by credit instead, so the film could be marketed as written and directed by Quentin Tarantino. At the Golden Globes, Tarantino accepted the screenplay award alone and did not mention Avary. The Academy took a different view and named them joint winners of Best Original Screenplay, the film's only Oscar win. The friction between the two men lasted for years, though they have since reconciled enough to co-host a movie podcast together, which is covered in the recommendations section.

One more piece of origin lore: TriStar Pictures had a first-look deal and passed on the script, reportedly calling it too demented and balking at a heroin-using protagonist. Avary recalled the studio's verdict as: this is the worst thing ever written, it makes no sense, someone is dead and then they are alive, it is too long, violent, and unfilmable. Harvey Weinstein's Miramax picked it

up as the first film it fully financed after being acquired by Disney. Eighteen months later that unfilmable script had the Palme d'Or.

## Themes and What Makes It Work

### The title is the thesis

The film opens with two dictionary definitions of pulp: a soft, moist, shapeless mass of matter, and a magazine or book containing lurid subject matter, printed on rough, unfinished paper. That is the whole project in a nutshell. Tarantino is making his own pulp magazine: sensational vignettes, seedy characters, graphic violence, told as an anthology and elevated by craft. The high-low blend, gutter material handled with art-film technique, is why critics reached for words like postmodern. The movie treats a foot massage debate and an execution with the same level of attention.

### The scrambled clock

The structure is the film's most famous trick. Seven sections, three main stories, and a chronology shuffled so that the movie opens and closes in the same diner during the same robbery. Watched in story order, the segments would run roughly 4-2-6-1-7-3-5 against what you see on screen. The payoff of the shuffle is Vincent Vega: he is shot dead by Butch in The Gold Watch, then walks back on screen for the final act because The Bonnie Situation and the diner epilogue happen earlier in time. A dead protagonist ordering breakfast is not a continuity error, it is the point. The structure lets the film end on Jules's moment of grace rather than on a body count, and it forces you to assemble the moral arc yourself. Tarantino has said he wanted to do what novelists get to do but filmmakers usually don't: tell three separate stories where characters float in and out with different weights depending on the story.

### Redemption in a pulp universe

Underneath the cool talk, the movie is about grace showing up in the least likely places. Jules Winnfield recites a mostly invented Bible verse, Ezekiel 25:17, as a death mantra before executions. When a hidden gunman empties a revolver at him from close range and misses every shot, Jules decides it was a miracle and chooses to walk the earth rather than keep killing. In the diner, he gets his chance to prove it, talking Pumpkin and Honey Bunny down instead of shooting them, and he reinterprets the verse out loud in one of the great closing monologues in American film. Butch gets the parallel arc: free and clear after the pawn shop nightmare, he turns around and saves the man who wants him dead, and mercy buys his freedom. Vincent, who scoffed at the miracle, is the one who does not make it. The film never announces any of this. It just arranges the pieces so the pattern is there if you look.

### The bathroom motif

Here is a pattern beloved by fans and film writers alike: disaster strikes whenever someone leaves a bathroom. The hidden gunman bursts out of the bathroom to fire at Jules and Vincent. Vincent steps out of Butch's bathroom into a machine-gun blast. The diner robbery kicks off while Vincent is in the toilet. There are layered readings: Vincent is a heroin user, and opiates

keep him in the bathroom a lot, reading a pulpy Modesty Blaise paperback, the classic bathroom reading that pulp magazines literally were. Whether you take it as a running joke about vulnerability or a thematic statement about fate catching people with their guard down, it is clearly deliberate, and it rewards a rewatch.

## Critical Reception

The consensus is about as strong as film criticism gets: 92 percent on Rotten Tomatoes with a 9.3 out of 10 critic average, and a 95 on Metacritic, which the site labels universal acclaim. Interestingly, opening-weekend audiences were cooler than the critics. The film's CinemaScore exit grade was a B+, a reminder of how divisive the violence and the scrambled timeline felt to mainstream 1994 audiences.

Roger Ebert was the film's most influential champion, comparing its construction to Citizen Kane and writing:

> *"This is filmmaking of a high order... so well-written in a scruffy, fanzine way that you want to rub noses in it."*
>
> *Roger Ebert, Chicago Sun-Times (1994)*

Two more raves capture the tone of the moment:

> *"The miracle of Quentin Tarantino's Pulp Fiction is how, being composed of secondhand, debased parts, it succeeds in gleaming like something new."*
>
> *David Ansen, Newsweek (1994)*
>
> *"It towers over the year's other movies as majestically and menacingly as a gang lord at a preschool."*
>
> *Richard Corliss, Time (1994)*

The dissent is worth knowing because it has never fully gone away. Kenneth Turan of the LA Times found creative desperation in its effects. Stanley Kauffmann in The New Republic wrote that the way the film had been so widely ravened up and drooled over verges on the disgusting. James Wood in The Guardian called it the final triumph of postmodernism, which is to empty the artwork of all content. Pauline Kael, in a mixed later assessment, said there is nothing under Pulp Fiction, no serious undercurrents, but granted it a crazy good humour. The recurring charge, dazzling surface over a hollow center, is the one serious critique the film still has to answer, and the redemption reading above is essentially the counterargument.

There was also real controversy at release over the violence and over the film's repeated use of a racial slur, spoken 18 times, including by Tarantino's own character Jimmie. Critic Todd Boyd argued the word's recurrence signified hipness for white males. That debate followed Tarantino for the rest of his career and later fueled his public feud with Spike Lee.

On the awards front, the arc runs from triumph to famous near-miss. It won the Palme d'Or at Cannes in May 1994, beating Kieslowski's Red in a jury year presided over by Clint Eastwood. At the Oscars it earned seven nominations, including Best Picture, Director, Actor (Travolta), Supporting Actor (Jackson), and Supporting Actress (Thurman), but won only Best Original Screenplay. Best Picture and Best Director went to Forrest Gump, an Oscar-night outcome that still anchors every argument about the Academy playing it safe. It also swept four Independent Spirit Awards and took Best Picture from several major critics' groups.

The box office is its own headline. Made for roughly $8.5 million, it grossed $107.9 million domestically and about $213.9 million worldwide, the first Miramax film to cross $100 million domestic. That roughly 25x return permanently changed what studios believed an independent film could do commercially.

## What You Might Not Know

### The casting could have gone very differently

- Vincent Vega was written for Michael Madsen, who played Vincent's brother Vic (Mr. Blonde) in Reservoir Dogs. Madsen chose Wyatt Earp instead. Harvey Weinstein then pushed hard for Daniel Day-Lewis, and Tarantino used his contractual cast-approval rights to hold the line for John Travolta, whose career had cratered. Travolta worked for a reported $100,000 to $140,000 and walked away with an Oscar nomination and one of the great career comebacks in Hollywood history.
- Samuel L. Jackson nearly lost Jules. Actor Paul Calderon impressed Tarantino so much in auditions that Jackson flew back to Los Angeles and re-auditioned, reportedly channeling the role's fury while eating a hamburger. Calderon got a consolation role as Paul the bartender.
- Miramax wanted Holly Hunter or Meg Ryan for Mia Wallace. Uma Thurman was hesitant until Tarantino read her the overdose scene over the phone. She later admitted the dance scene terrified her more than almost anything.
- Butch was offered to Matt Dillon and Mickey Rourke before Bruce Willis took it. Producer Lawrence Bender paid every principal actor the same weekly rate, so Willis worked for scale, but his name pre-sold roughly $11 million in worldwide rights, meaning the film was essentially profitable before it opened.

### Production tricks on an indie budget

- Tarantino told his crew he wanted the $8 million film to look like a $20 to 25 million one. He shot on slow, fine-grain 50 ASA film stock for a clean Technicolor-style look.
- The single biggest expense was the Jack Rabbit Slim's set, about $150,000, built in a Culver City warehouse. The diner from the opening and closing scenes was the real Hawthorne Grill in Hawthorne, California, since demolished and replaced by an auto parts store.
- The adrenaline shot was filmed in reverse. Travolta started with the needle touching Uma Thurman's chest and yanked it away; the film was run backward so it appears to plunge in.

Tarantino borrowed the adrenaline-shot idea from a story in Martin Scorsese's documentary American Boy.

- Tarantino cast himself as Jimmie partly so he could stay behind the camera for the technically demanding overdose sequence.

### The borrowed parts

- The Ezekiel 25:17 speech is mostly invented. Only the final lines resemble the actual verse; the bulk was adapted from the opening of the 1973 Sonny Chiba martial arts film Karate Kiba (The Bodyguard).
- The twist contest is an homage to the Madison dance scene in Godard's Bande a part (1964). Tarantino has complained that everyone assumes he wrote the scene to show off Travolta dancing; it existed before Travolta was cast. His production company, A Band Apart, is named after the Godard film.
- The glowing briefcase nods to the 1955 noir Kiss Me Deadly. In the original script it held diamonds, which Tarantino decided was too boring. He has confirmed there is no canonical answer; it is a deliberate MacGuffin. On set, the glow came from a hidden orange light bulb and batteries.

### The connected universe

- Red Apple cigarettes and Big Kahuna Burger are fictional brands that recur across Tarantino's films, quiet connective tissue years before shared universes were fashionable.
- Tarantino long planned a Vega brothers prequel reuniting Vincent and Vic. Both characters die in their films, and the actors aged out of the timeline, so it never happened.
- Costume designer Betsy Heimann dressed Jules and Vincent in matching black suits as symbolic armor, a nod to the French crime films of Jean-Pierre Melville. Watch how the armor comes off: by the diner scene they are in gym shorts and t-shirts.

## Cultural Context

Pulp Fiction sits at the hinge of 1990s American film. Before it, independent cinema meant art houses and modest returns. After it, every studio wanted an indie division and every festival wanted the next Tarantino. The film validated Miramax's entire model and set off a decade of imitators full of chatty hitmen, retro needle drops, and shuffled timelines. Most copied the surface and missed what made it work: the precise control of what the audience knows and when. The best of the imitator wave, Doug Liman's Go, is in the recommendations below.

The soundtrack was its own cultural event. There is no composed score; Tarantino curated surf rock, soul, and pop instead, opening on Dick Dale's Misirlou and threading in Chuck Berry, Dusty Springfield, and Urge Overkill's cover of Neil Diamond's Girl, You'll Be a Woman Soon. The soundtrack album went multi-platinum and made needle-drop curation a directorial signature that half of Hollywood still chases.

The film also connects backward to a real literary tradition. The pulp magazines it salutes, especially Black Mask, founded in 1920, invented hardboiled crime fiction: terse, violent, morally

gray, dialogue-forward. Hammett, Chandler, and James M. Cain are the film's literary grandparents, and Elmore Leonard is the modern bridge; Tarantino adapted Leonard directly for his next film, Jackie Brown.

The Library of Congress added Pulp Fiction to the National Film Registry in 2013. For the 30th anniversary in 2024, Variety published a large oral history and the cast reunited at the TCM Classic Film Festival, where Uma Thurman said the film changed cinema and changed every filmmaker she has ever met, and Samuel L. Jackson noted, in saltier language, that it permanently changed how the world saw him.

## If You Liked This

Five films, in rough order of relevance:

- Reservoir Dogs (1992). Tarantino's debut and the closest companion piece: nonlinear heist story, pop-culture-laced dialogue, and Vincent Vega's brother in the cast.
- Jackie Brown (1997). Tarantino's follow-up, adapted from Elmore Leonard's Rum Punch. Slower and more novelistic, and the purest expression of the pulp-crime literary tradition behind the title.
- Go (1999). The best film of the Pulp Fiction imitator wave: three interwoven stories showing different sides of the same chaotic night. A genuine deep cut that holds up.
- Lock, Stock and Two Smoking Barrels (1998). Guy Ritchie's debut, the British counterpart: interlocking criminals, verbal wit, and caper energy.
- Goodfellas (1990). The naturalistic elder statesman of 90s crime cinema. Where Pulp Fiction is a collage, Scorsese's film is the real-world touchstone that fed Tarantino's generation.

Companion media, if you want to go deeper:

- Cinema Speculation (2022), Tarantino's book of essays on the 1970s films that built his brain. Not about Pulp Fiction directly, but it is the source code.
- The Video Archives Podcast, hosted by Tarantino and Roger Avary, the film's co-writer. The two review old movies from the shelves of the video store where the whole thing started.
- QT8: The First Eight (2019), a career documentary covering Reservoir Dogs and Pulp Fiction as the breakthrough chapter. Note that it also covers the Weinstein controversy; it is not purely celebratory.
- For the literary ancestors: Hammett's The Maltese Falcon, Chandler's The Big Sleep, and James M. Cain's Double Indemnity are the hardboiled classics the title salutes.

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